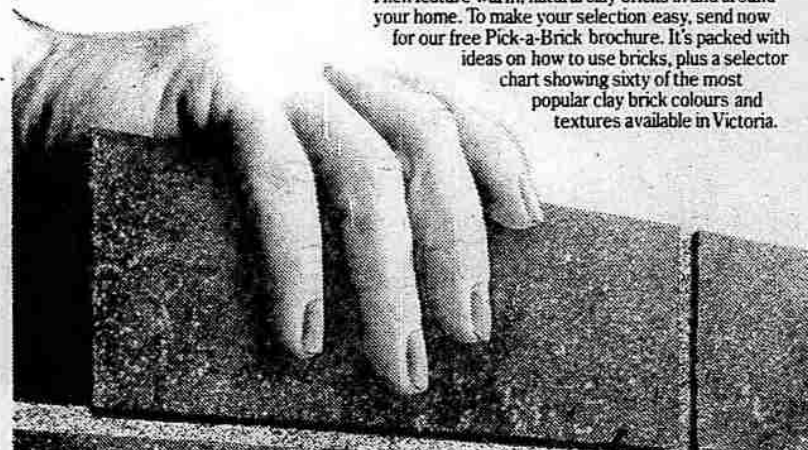


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MELBOURNE LIVING 4

Bravery award earned at Show

Continued from Living 2

the animal nursery and thence to my favorite, the Poultry Hall. Cage upon cage of gorgeous birds — the prize White Leghorn quite six times the size of my own thoroughly spoilt pair.

Chinese balls of feather with great fluffy slippers, a frizzle red rooster who looked like he'd suffered an electric shock, tall Malay game cocks with long, strong, spurred legs and great muscular upright thighs supporting a small body and long powerful neck — a fighting machine; Indian runner ducks, the sweetest slimmest things, elegant as a little finger, they run along upright — cartoon ducks; and the prize geese, heavy as battleships, fat as mud and doomed to stew.

On to arts and crafts, though by this time I knew I was pushing my luck. The kids were tired by now and it was time to go home.

I cannot imagine when I will be inspired to take children to the Show again, if ever. I can imagine taking myself though — a nice Devonshire Tea, the odd hot donut, maybe a licorice showbag even — then a good long look at the arts and crafts and hours and hours in the poultry hall. Who knows, one year I might end up with a prize matinee jacket I've tatted out of chook-feathers and decorated with pink sugar roses. Lovely!

— Sharon Gray

BENEATH THE SUDS PART 1

MAUREEN STEWART reports on life in a laundrette, the first of a two-part series.

As long as there is a laundrette within striking distance, I could not own a washing machine. I would be missing out on so much.

My weekly visit is one of the highlights of my week — and I lead anything but a dull life. I experimented for years with laundrettes, as others do with wines, and I have found one that suits me perfectly. It has the right mix of regulars, eccentrics, ages and magazines.

You can recognise regulars almost as soon as they walk in the open glass door. They carry their own soap powder, laundry basket, paperback, and they check out the unused machines for unwanted left articles, which they throw dramatically on to the communal

ledge. They always have the right change, even if their drying cycle needs four spins.

My favorite eccentric is a pram lady, Richmond (where my laundrette nestles) abounds in these street people — the pram ladies are street people of older vintage than those who strut to be seen in Fitzroy or Carlton. Pram ladies are indifferent to their watchers. My pram lady (we do speak, but in monosyllables — she has learnt to distrust the world) favors the laundrette with a visit on carefully chosen occasions. She watches through the glass to check that there are dryers free and several machines free as well. If the situation does not fit her bill, she moves on after picking treasures from the rubbish bin outside.

If the emptiness of the laundrette satisfies her, she and her pram enter regally. She checks the empty machines for left articles — she finds many, and once became orgasmic over a petticoat. She takes everything from the communal ledge, carefully appraising each article before adding it to her pram.

She then sits and waits until someone leaves his or her dryer spinning and rushes out to fit in some shopping. Oblivious to other customers' watching, she takes a

bottle of water from her pram. Then comes her big act — I've seen it dozens of times. Pram ladies wear layers of clothes — perhaps through modesty. My pram lady stands in a corner, shakes her lithe old body, and presto! Down fall her pink, floppy knickers. She sprinkles them with water from her bottle, then squeezes them carefully and adds them to the clothes in the temporarily deserted dryer. The knickers dry quickly, and she retrieves them before the unsuspecting customer returns.

Twice she did not make it on time. Three of us watched with interest as the shopper returned. She waited until the end of the cycle, indicated to the returned shopper that she had left an article in the dryer and demanded it back. It worked both times — it says something about people that not one of her audience gave her away.

My pram lady folds her knickers carefully and takes off, knickerless, into the streets, her puckered, toothless mouth fixed in a timeless smile of guile.

SHARON has become a regular laundrette friend. She is there twice weekly, and I manage to catch her about twice a month. Like me, her work hours are flexible. When I asked what she did for a living, she answered, "Nothing, really, I'm a public servant". On closer questioning, she had little to add — it seems she is being accurate, not modest.

Sharon first caught my interest when I heard her muttering as she threw clothes angrily into her chosen machine. Her muttering became more intense when she hurled underpants and socks. I caught snatches of her intended soliloquy — "has never washed my bra", "wouldn't know if I had a clean blouse", "never again". She seemed too distraught to speak to that first time, and she retreated to a chair with her Mills and Boon and cigarettes, consuming both with frenetic intensity.

Sharon repeated her mutterings next time I saw her — and I gathered courage to speak. I'm glad I did — she was delighted to forsake her Mills and Boon and regale me with her woes. It appears her live-in boyfriend has never washed anything in his life, or made the bed, or even a cup of coffee. I suggested, somewhat tamely, that she talk this over with



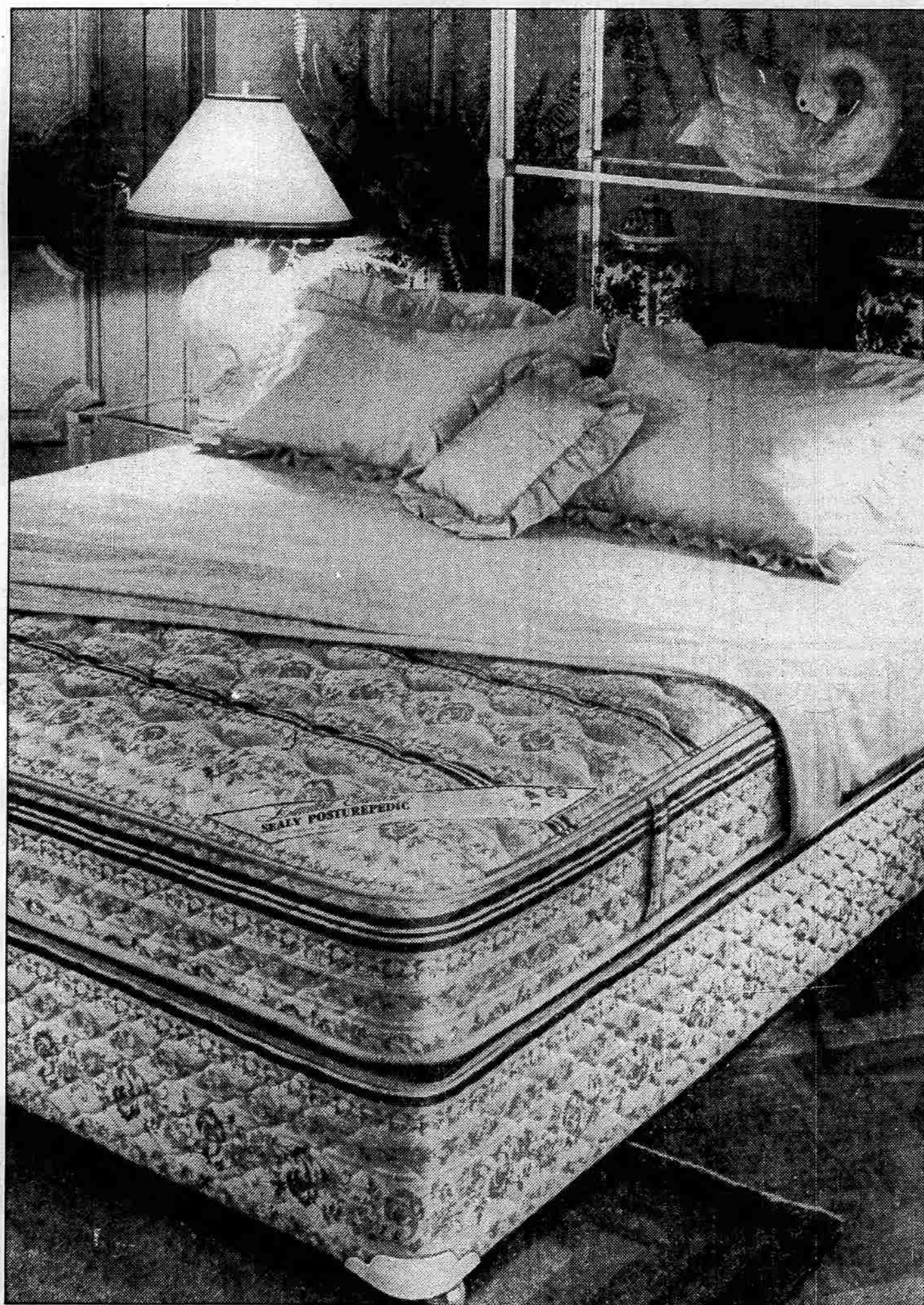
him and try to work out some sort of compromise. Sharon was shocked by this radical suggestion, telling me that she knew that women were supposed to do these things, but that sometimes it got her down, and it did her good to talk about it.

Sharon lets off steam at the laundrette. I now know more about her sex life than I care to — "only when it suits him" stuff. I do

try to tell her life needn't be like that, but, in a strange way, she accepts her lot, and gets by by complaining about it. I'm not sure how sorry I feel for the Sharons of this world. Sometimes I hear her telling other customers her grievances — she seems to thrive on them. Maybe the Public Service is the best place for her.

Part II next week.

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Single ensemble	\$695
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Purifying pollies' prolixities

Continued from Living 1

bottom line. You can come up with the "main thrust of my argument". That, too, is worth \$5.

They talk of facilities. A school is an education facility and an auto-enclosing facility is a garage: \$1. Then they go in for capabilities. You can have a dollar capability, a wheat capability and a defence capability. We are depending on a tax capability to extract 50 cents for every one of those.

Parliament is not just Parliament, it is a decision-making process. But are we businessmen, public servants or farmers? Certainly not. We are the private sector, the public sector and the rural sector: \$1.

No longer do you trade; you find new customers in the market place to whom you sell right across the board. How do you improve your performance? Why, you do your homework and you utilise in-depth reports.

Each of those words carry a dollar fine for first-time offenders.

MPs never talk about 10 per cent inflation, it is double digit. They don't talk about rights, they are always untrammelled. How could they have faith without its being blind? Nor can they see things with clarity unless it is brutal. Nor can we have infamy without the day of infamy that lives forever in our minds.

This adjectival section carries a fine-rate of 50 cents, with a dollar for second and third offences.

Things are not cheap this year, nor are they inexpensive. They are affordable. You do not describe anything as wonderful; it is magic. When an item is new, the ultimate in modernity, do you know what they are saying? It is the state of the art.

For these we will make on-the-spot fines of \$2 an offence.

However, there are some words being used in the House that are so weary, so awful, so overdone that the Purification Bill is planning punitive fines in the hope they will be driven for ever from Hansard:

Low profile; light at the end of the tunnel; driver's dog; gut feeling; input; feedback; ad hoc; per se; pragmatism; reaching consensus; near future; not-too-distant future; tip of the iceberg; in fact, in point of fact; dialogue (and worse) meaningful dialogue; hopefully; ongoing; modernistic; rapt; this day and age; forward-looking policies.

All these words will incur on-the-spot fines of \$20 with annual marginal adjustments for inflation. Naturally, this is just a glimpse, a sample, of the full range of words that will appear in the bill. More certainly will be added during the committee stages and when it comes up for the second reading in the Senate.

According to my ad hoc calculations, made on Treasury guidelines and parameters it should raise \$72.5 million in the coming fiscal year.

— Keith Dunstan

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